

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Reed at a roastery
How a concert dedicated to ‘flute’ Mali came as a breath of fresh air **p2**

For a dramatic entry
‘Patra Pravesha Daruvu’ explored a key element of Kuchipudi **p3**



A HIMALAYAN TASK

Rapper Unniyal’s track carries a call to protect the mountain range **p4**

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It’s a warm, humid morning. As Sudharani Raghupathy, draped elegantly in a pink sari, walks into the sunlit space between her home and dance school, Bharatalaya, in Chennai’s Mylapore, you notice a slight limp in her step. “It’s not age, I just hurt my toe,” she laughs, settling down to talk about dance. But instead of retreating into nostalgia, she seems curious about what lies ahead. Listening to the Bharatanatyam legend – poised, articulate and full of vitality – you cannot help wondering whether age matters at all.

As her conversation moves seamlessly from the present to the past, Sudharani proves you wrong should you think technology is the preserve of Gen Z. At 82, she speaks of it with ease and has strong views too. “I agree AI can do anything. You feed it millions of permutations and combinations. But there is something beyond it, which only the human brain can do,” she says. “When we improvise abhinaya in a padam, can the AI reproduce it? Because we are responding on the spot, on stage, at that very moment. That’s art.”

Sudharani punctuates the thought with a brief, eloquent abhinaya – a fleeting smile, an arched brow, a roll of her Kohl-rimmed eyes, a tilt of the head and hands that transform into precise mudras. She evokes a lifetime spent perfecting stance, movement and expression under revered *vadhyars*.

Chosen recently for the Sangeet Natak Akademi Fellowship (Akademi Ratna), she embodies the essence of dance: a space where tradition, spontaneity and emotion converge beyond the reach of machines.

“The award is a reaffirmation of my faith in the lineage of the Thanjavur Quartet, who gave the dance form its repertoire and structure. I am fortunate to have belonged to that *parampara*. I am only a link, like many others. But it’s not just my achievement, it takes a whole band of people to create something enduring,” she says, her words carrying both humility and pride.

This collaborative spirit was something she imbibed at



A lifetime in expression

Chosen for the Sangeet Natak Akademi Fellowship, Sudharani Raghupathy, who has long been ahead of her time, talks about art in the AI era while underscoring the irreducible human element in dance

home and through her approach to art. She juggled the roles of wife, mother and daughter-in-law with that of an artiste, while holding firmly to the belief that being a dancer alone was not enough to be creative.

“After my husband and children left for office and school, and once I was done with the household chores, I would shut myself in a room every day for a dedicated practice session. There were days when I did not get enough time to rehearse before a

performance, but my daily *sadhakam* always came in handy.

“My world revolved almost entirely around home and art. I never really got to make friends or socialise, but my artistic pursuits gave me a sense of fellowship and inspiration.”

One such enriching association was

with craft revivalist Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay. “Through my interactions with artisans, I learnt pottery, embroidery, fabric printing and weaving. I built up a large collection of handcrafted saris with unique motifs designed by me. Recently, during a visit to a village, I realised I had not forgotten those skills. I sat down and made a few small pots,” she recalls.

According to Sudharani, a complete dancer must appreciate other art and craft forms as well. “They deepen your creative sensibilities and help you engage with the art in a far more personal and meaningful way.”

These pursuits beyond dance also shaped her social outlook.

Discrimination and social divides rarely figured in conversations at home or in her school. “Caste makes no sense to me. Whatever your background, your art should be your identity. More than anything else, what matters is acceptance by the audience. Once that bond is established, everything else fades into oblivion.”

Though rooted in a traditional learning environment under gurus and scholars such as K.P. Kittappa Pillai, U.S. Krishna Rao and Mylapore Gowri Ammal, and trained in Carnatic music by violin maestro T. Chowdiah and vidwan Madurai N. Krishnan, Sudharani’s artistic vision was never constrained by convention.

“Two things I learnt early on were never to suppress the ‘I’. It must be there; if it collapses, you might lose the curiosity to

expand your horizons. The second was never to say ‘no’ to an opportunity, even if it meant stepping out of your comfort zone.”

She embodied this philosophy, when, in 1964, she became one of the first Indians at Randolph-Macon Woman’s College in Virginia. There, she studied the history of world dance and studio arts, trained in the Martha Graham technique and learnt Western music from Elaine St. Vincent.

“The Martha Graham technique is a departure from traditional ballet, with its emphasis on breath, contraction and release rather than ballet’s verticality and reliance on pointe work. I realised that we already had some of these principles in our own system. So my body responded to it naturally. Once back home, I never tried to fuse the technique into my performances because our country offers such a vast range of styles, even within a single genre.”

That said, she is welcoming of those who choose to experiment with the form.

“Why not?” she asks. “After all, art is about communication. The real question is: what are you communicating? If you want popularity or awards, that is fine. But what are you giving your audience? There will always be criticism, but that should not stop you from trying. If people can connect with it, go ahead.”

An instinct that is both refreshing and heartening. “Growing old does not mean closing yourself to newness. If Brahma were to ask me what I wanted – youth, beauty, fame or money – I would say, ‘Give me the vision: the ability to look ahead. The past has been wonderful, but I am curious to see where our culture takes us as technology and tradition negotiate new ways of coexisting,” she says with a warm smile.

Expansive vision
Sudharani believes a dancer must appreciate other art and craft forms.
PHOTOS: B. THAMODHARAN

CULTURE BRIEFS



In the Arena

Yagnaraman July Fest 2026 (YJF) will be hosted at the KGS Arena, conceived in memory of R. Yagnaraman. It will celebrate diverse musical genres. Though known for hosting classical arts for many decades, the Arena plans to showcase other styles that define the city.

The festival’s opens on July 4 with ‘QFR Live: ARR Ragas’, curated by Subhasree Thanikachalam. Rather than a conventional cover concert, the event explores the classical roots of

A.R. Rahman’s cinematic work. Rahman’s compositions from Sufi, qawwali and bhajans to thumri will be presented by singers Santosh, Sai Vignesh, Vidya Kalyanaraman and Disha.

On July 5, ‘Kelu Kelu Kelu – Idhu Office Gaana Musical’ brings together more than 11 artistes in a fusion of folk percussion with multilingual narratives, dance, sketch-style drama, and satire on modern workspace culture. The event will be held at 6.30 p.m. at Krishna Gana Sabha, T. Nagar. Tickets are available via MDnD.

A grand continuation

Aaha!, a digital dance festival, conceived by Aravinth Kumarasamy (artistic director of the Singapore-based Apsaras Dance Company) launched on June 1, is now into its fourth week. Hosted on AVAL.video, the festival is presented in collaboration with *The Hindu*.

It presents a collection of works that celebrate the many dimensions of the tradition and brings together well-known artistes and choreographers. Week four promises a thought-provoking journey through movement, music, poetry, and storytelling.

This week’s ‘The Masters Series’ will feature Bharatanatyam dancer Vaibhav Arekar in ‘Eka Arohana’ – an interpretation of Sant Ekanath’s philosophy of divine oneness through poetry and movement.

Following this is dancer-scholar Janaki

Rangarajan’s ‘Impure OR I’m PURE’, which confronts the taboo of menstruation, inviting reflection on dignity, womanhood and the need to re-examine inherited social narratives.

This also includes Vidhya Subramanian’s ‘Damaru’, which explores creation, destruction, rhythm, and silence through Shiva’s symbolic drum, becoming a meditation on Ardhnari, duality, and the perpetual cycles of existence.

The Rising Stars Series presents Kshirja Govind from Singapore, who will present love, betrayal and longing through Husseni raga Swarajathi, while Shreema Upadhyaya’s ‘Adikondar’ will bring alive the splendour of Nataraja’s cosmic dance. The Ensemble Series will feature ‘Vastu’ by Apsaras Dance Company, inspired by Vastu Shastra and its vision of sacred geometry, cosmic balance, and divine energy.



Russian music in the city

Russian House in Chennai hosts an evening of Russian classical music on June 27, 6.30 p.m. at its venue, as part of the ‘Embassy of Musical Mastery’ concert series.

This special chamber concert, presented by the Saint Petersburg Music House, will feature masterpieces by three well-known Russian composers – Sergey Prokofiev, Pyotr Tchaikovsky and Sergey Rachmaninov.

The concert will be performed by young musicians and laureates of international competitions: Petr Khudonogov (Flute), Gleb-Iosif

Romanchukovich (Piano).

The first part of the programme is dedicated to the 135th birth anniversary of Sergey Prokofiev and includes his celebrated ‘Sonata for Flute and Piano’, excerpts from the ballet ‘Romeo and Juliet’ and the famous ‘March’ from the opera ‘The Love for Three Oranges’.

The second part will feature Pyotr Tchaikovsky’s piano cycle ‘The Seasons’ and Sergey Rachmaninov’s magnificent ‘Six Moments Musicaux’, offering audiences an opportunity to experience some of the finest works of the Russian classical repertoire. For tickets call +91-44-2499 0050.

The ebb and flow

‘Aham Pravahini’ traced a river’s journey

V.V. Ramani

The poem *Fear* by Khalil Gibran begins with the line, *It is said that before entering the sea, a river trembles with fear*. This journey of the river and its emotions expressed in the poem inspired Shobana Bhalchandra to conceptualise and choreograph ‘Aham Pravahini’, which was staged at Kalakshetra. While Preeti Anand co-produced the show, the musical soundscape was conceived and scored by Embar Kannan.

The presentation opened with the tracing of a river’s journey as it flows from the mountains. This was depicted through the out-stretched hands of two dancers. Then a group of eight became the river, tracing its passage through various terrains, reflecting the cultural practices it nourishes during its course. The popular Bengali song, ‘Ekla chalo re’ not only established the landscape of Kolkata but also the river’s solitary journey. Familiar scenes such as the Ganga arathi with lit lamps lining the ghats at Benares and folk dances celebrating a bountiful harvest were woven into the narrative. The dance progressed

showing the river’s travails through changing seasons. The vigour that it displays during this travel turns into fear when it is time for the river to merge with the ocean.

The dancers draped in blue costumes conveyed these ideas through diverse movements. However, repetitive formations, with limited exploration of group dynamics, lent a sense of monotony. The choreography would have been more effective had it moved beyond routine depiction of riverside activities to delve into the river’s emotions at different stages. This would have conveyed better the core theme of fear.

Given the rich possibilities that Bharatanatyam offers to showcase ideas through gestures, it would have been effective to rely on these aspects of natya rather than on props.

Embar Kannan’s musical score captured well the mood of the sequences through appropriate ragas. Guru Bharadhwaj’s rhythmic syllables evoked the fall of raindrops, enhancing the impact of the scene. Lighting design was by Charles.

‘Aham Pravahini’ is an engaging concept that would benefit from greater emotional intensity.

Perfect brew

A tribute concert, dedicated to ‘flute’ Mali, at a roastery blended performance and discussion



Swaroop with M. Vijay on the violin and Anirudh Athreya on the kanjira.

‘Ninnuvina’ in Navarasa Kannada. The recording offered a glimpse into the evolution of the Carnatic flute, whose concert history spans little more than a century. While pioneers such as Sarabha Sastri and Palladam Sanjeeva Rao established it as a classical concert instrument, Mali expanded its expressive possibilities by adopting a thicker bamboo flute and developing a unique playing technique.

Among the recordings presented was Mali’s celebrated Sindhuhairavi RTP, a piece that exemplified why he remains one of Carnatic music’s most unconventional and influential figures. The recording revealed how he could stretch the boundaries of a raga, momentarily leading listeners into unfamiliar sonic territory before effortlessly re-establishing its identity. Swaroop observed that, for a musician celebrated for challenging conventions, Mali could, at times, be remarkably faithful to tradition. Even as he ventured beyond the rules in ragas such as Nalinakanti and Begada, he retained certain archaic usages, such as the employment of the shatsruti daivatam in ‘Bantu reethi’ in Hamsanadam. According to some scholars, this reflects an earlier, perhaps original, manner of rendering the raga and composition. Swaroop then presented a short Behag RTP, followed by a ragamalika suite featuring ragas associated with Mali – Varali, Bilahari, Anandhabhairavi and Ahiri. Vijay alternated with Swaroop in the ragamalika, before Anirudh’s tani avartanam.

The programme concluded with Bharatiyar’s ‘Chinnanchiru kiliyē’, followed by a recording of Mali’s celebrated ‘Magudi’, a piece that came to embody his free-spirited musical personality. M. Vijay’s violin and Anirudh Athreya’s kanjira blended seamlessly with Swaroop’s flute, creating a balanced and responsive ensemble.



experience.

After recounting how he learnt the Vagadeeshwari kriti ‘Paramatmudu’ from his guru, N. Ramani, Swaroop presented the composition with kalpanaswaras. In a nod to Mali’s style, he moved into Tisra nadai during the swara passages before rounding them off with a neat Tisra-nadai korvai. Observing that most surviving recordings of Mali belong to the latter part of his career, Swaroop introduced listeners to a 1951 gramophone recording of

conventional concert. Combining live flute renditions with archival recordings of Mali, he offered listeners insights into the maestro’s work and its enduring influence. Interspersed with explanations and anecdotes, the programme unfolded as an engaging blend of performance and conversation.

For many music lovers, Mali remains an enigmatic persona, whose spontaneous and unpredictable approach to performance gave his music a larger-than-life quality. Taking the well-known Mohanam varnam ‘Ninnu Kori’ as an example, Swaroop demonstrated how Mali approached the chittaswarams – not as fixed phrases but as opportunities for invention, varying speeds and rhythmic accents – even within a single avartana to create an ever-changing musical

CALENDAR

In memory of a veteran

The Music Academy has organised the following programmes in memory of the legendary violinist Dwaram Venkataswamy Naidu, under the endowment, instituted by his family. Details: Today, 6 p.m.: S.M. Subhani’s mandolin recital with V.V. Ravi on the violin) and Parupalli Phalgun on the mridangam. June 27, 10 a.m.: ‘Mula Abhyasa’, a violin workshop, to be conducted by senior violinist Embar Kannan. Learn the fundamentals and practice techniques at the session, which is open to students and rasikas. For registration and other details call 2811 2231/2811 5162. Venue: Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.



Strings in sync

Paalam conducts a six-day violin festival from July 1 to 6, 6.30 p.m. Performances by senior and young vainikas will be streamed live on www.paalamtv.com. The curtains go up with the concert by Parur M.A. Krishnaswamy, Parur M.K. Ananthalakshmi and Parur M.K. Ananthabalasubramaniam. Artists to perform from July 2 to 6 are: Iyer Sisters; B. Ananthakrishnan and Shreeya Ananth; Ananya and Ameya; P.V. Saiprasad and P.V. Sainandan; and Deepika and Nandika.

A quiet commitment

Aalaap has curated a new performance series ‘Quietly Dancing’, dancers who engage deeply with their practice regardless of external noise or circumstance. The series launches with the performance of Chennai-based dancer Nitya Sriram, disciple of Leela Samson. It will be held on June 27, 3 p.m., at Narada Gana Sabha mini hall.

Revisiting rare varnams

To celebrate the richness, and beauty of varnams, a two-day festival titled ‘Varnajalam’, will be presented by Lalitha Arts & Music Promotion Social Trust (LAMPS) in partnership with Vaak Foundation, on June 27 and 28, 5.30 p.m. at M.S. Subbulakshmi Arangam, Asian College of Journalism.

The festival brings together eight well-known dancers who will present eight varnams across four thoughtfully curated sessions. The performing artistes are: Meenakshi Chitharanjan; Narthaki Natraj; Karuna Sagari; Priya Murlie; Swarnamalya Ganesh; Parshwanath Upadhye; Shwetha Prachande and Vidhya Subramanian. The two-day event begins with Narthaki Natraj’s performance (5.30 p.m.). The senior Bharatanatyam dancer will revisit Kittappa Pillai’s Ashta talamalika varnam. Tickets on KYN app.



Mahadevan Sankaranarayanan (vocal) accompanied by M.R. Gopinath (violin), Melakaveri Balaji (mridangam) and Anirudh Athreya (kanjira). PHOTO: S. R. RAGHUNTHAN

A confident outing

T.V.S. Mahadevan’s concert featured frequent swara passages, affecting its balance

P Srihari

Pedigree can be a perilous boon. A lifeline for some who wear it lightly and a daunting burden for some who buckle under it. More often, it is a mid-ridge from which the desired destination is visible yet distant.

T.V.S. Mahadevan, son and disciple of the legendary T.V. Sankaranarayanan, showcased the upside of his lineage through much of his vocal concert for the Chennai Fine Arts at Srinivasa Sastri Hall. He presented an energy-laden recital in the company of senior artistes – M.R. Gopinath on the violin and Melakaveri Balaji on the mridangam – and Anirudh Athreya on the kanjira. Mahadevan sang with striking confidence, especially in the kalpanaswara segments – five in the seven kritis. But that was too many, given the contrast: there was a solitary niraval of barely three avartanam. He would also do well to curb his tendency to frequently turn away from the microphone.

‘Pranatosmi devam’ on Vinayaka, a composition by Thulaseevanam, ushered in an off-beat opening, and Mahadevan capped it with a swara sequence of unhesitating flair. Swati Tirunal’s ‘Paripalaya maam’ in Ritigowlai-Rupakam followed, a kriti whose spacious gait in the opening of the charanam and brisk ending thereof provide a pleasant contrast. A second swara burst, with glimpses of his father’s trademark passages in the top octave, completed the kriti.

Kasiramakriya, the 51st raga in the asampurna mela paddhati, was the first raga explored by Mahadevan, and he developed it with clarity and elan. It was a well-rounded effort, despite a voice strain in the upper registers. Gopinath’s response was short and sweet. Dikshitar’s ‘Visalakshmi visvesim’ (in Misra Chapu tala) was the kriti chosen. Like many of the songs by the composer, this one is in the dwiteeya vibhakti (objective case), but the whole composition was sung in the nominative case as ‘Visalakshi visvesi’ (dropping the terminal ‘m’ which stands for the objective case). The pallavi is an exhortation to the mind to ‘always worship goddess

Visalakshi, the ruler of the Universe’. Here, the verb leans on the object, making the use of the nominative case grammatically incorrect and contrary to authentic sources. It is surprising that even some of the well-known artistes have adopted this version. The snappy niraval at ‘Kasi rajnim kapalanim’ in the samashti charanam also followed the same course, without the ‘m’.

Dictional purity (patantara suddham) is not merely imperative but integral to musical fidelity. The swarakalpana segment brought the best out of the team – sharp, riveting and well-coordinated.

Notably, the tala of the kriti is another point of intrigue. Unlike Tyagaraja and Syama Sastri, Dikshitar never went beyond the confines of the Suladi Sapta talas. The Kasiramakriya kriti was composed in Tisra Triputa, having the same count (seven) as Misra Chapu, which is not part of the Suladi framework. Perhaps owing to the influence of iconic kritis of the other two of the triumvirate and/or for sheer convenience, several of Dikshitar’s compositions in the seven-beat cycle have transitioned to Misra Chapu over time, and have come to stay that way.

Mahadevan delineated a flowing alapana in Kapi, the main melody of the evening. Flashy phrases and sustained notes brought out the myriad hues of the raga. He hurried through the Tyagaraja kriti ‘Inta sowkhyamani ne’, but followed it up with the most captivating phase of the concert. In a lengthy yet engaging swarakalpana, Mahadevan unleashed effortless formations, particularly in the second speed. The sarvalaghu patterns therein displayed exceptional felicity, though they bordered on excess. The percussion partners – Balaji and Anirudh – wove a measured tani avartanam in two-kalai Adi tala, underscoring their rhythmic excellence.

Muthiah Bhagavatar’s Hamsanandi kriti ‘Needu mahima pogada’, a Kambur verse as a virutham leading into Purandaradasa’s devaranama ‘Rama rama rama’ in Thilang and ‘Karpagame’, the Papanasam Sivan classic in Madhyamavati, formed a good mix for the back-end section.



N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Satyabhama enters the stage with regal confidence, proclaiming her radiance, grace and cherished place in Krishna’s heart. Within moments, her entrance emotional intensity, which defines her character and serves as an archway into the drama itself. Character-entry songs occupy a significant place in Indian performance traditions. While the Sanskrit dramatic tradition accords importance to pravesa and the Natyashastra describes dhruva songs for dramatic junctures, Kuchipudi’s ‘Patra Pravesha Daruvu’ combines these functions by introducing the character, establishing the mood and identity, and showcasing the performer’s abilities.

This rich tradition of character-introduction formed the thematic focus in Madhavapeddi Murthy’s recent presentation, along with the disciples of Siva Foundation, at Spaces. Conceived as an exploration of ‘Patra Praveshas’ in the Kuchipudi repertoire, the programme brought together several iconic compositions.

Murthy’s guru, Kuchipudi exponent Vempati Chinna Satyam, transformed the regional form into a sophisticated stage-tradition through a vast repertoire of dance-dramas –

The art of arrival

Patra Pravesha Daruvu showed why a character’s entry matters in the Kuchipudi tradition



integrating narratives, music and choreography with theatrical precision. Equally significant was his creation of role-specific movement vocabulary and emphasis on nritya within Pravesha Daruvus. These aspects were reflected in the programme through Murthy’s exploration of

the majesty of Shiva as Nataraja. He used the composition ‘Ananda Thandavam’ and the arrogant king Sishupala’s entrance from ‘Rukmini Kalyanam’, where bold charis and intricate jatis underscored the king’s valour and strength. The programme opened with

Delving into daruvu From the performance at Spaces.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Prathiba’s portrayal of Ganesha, followed by a series of compositions choreographed by Vempati Chinna Satyam. Aruna presented ‘Kanjadalayatakshi’ as Kamakshi, Sneha Mohan performed a Thiruppugazh depicting Murugan, and Susmitha Chakkungal brought to life Yashoda with ‘Muddugare yashoda’. Other characters adapted from dance-dramas included Narada from ‘Srinivasa Kalyanam’; Krishna through a Tarangam. Although it featured intricate rhythmic footwork, the presentation did not incorporate the brass-plate dance, often associated with the traditional rendering of the ‘Tarangam’. Neither did the production employ the traditional thiraseela (curtain), which ordinarily forms an integral part of the ‘Patra Pravesha’ by concealing the character until the moment of revelation, thereby heightening the dramatic impact of the Daruvu.

Group presentations put the spotlight on the diversity of roles in Kuchipudi dance-dramas. Vedalera Vaiyaru from ‘Vipranarayana Charitram’, offered a glimpse into the world of the courtesans – Devadevi and Madhuravani depicting them adorning themselves with ornaments and setting out to meet Vipranarayana. In contrast, Eruka from ‘Padmavati Kalyanam’ featured the fortune-teller. Together, the two excerpts highlighted the dramatic functions of characters in the Kuchipudi repertoire.

Alongside the traditional repertoire, Murthy and his students presented a series of newly-choreographed works in a contemporary idiom, exploring Ravana and Shurpanakha besides stylised depictions of a cow and a peacock.

The programme offered a glimpse into the expressive possibilities of ‘Patra Pravesha’.

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Public Hall of Madras Trail at Victoria Public Hall June 26, 2026 | 5-6 PM

Street Jam with OTS at Pandy Bazaar Performance by Melo Bee June 27, 2026 | 7-8.30 PM

Canvas by the Beach at Marina Beach June 27, 2026 | 6-8 AM

Chef's Table by Chef Mathangi Kumar at Mad.Co June 27, 2026 | 1-3 PM

Chasing Colours & Textures Walk at Nungambakkam June 27, 2026 | 5.30-6.30 PM

Street Jam with OTS at Khader Nawaz Khan Rd Performance by Anbu and team June 27, 2026 | 6-7.30 PM

Street Jam with OTS at Buckingham Canal - Park Town Open mic by Janish and Janani June 27, 2026 | 5-6 PM

Street Jam with OTS at Pandy Bazaar Performance by Nilauranotes June 28, 2026 | 7-8.30 PM

Chasing Colours & Textures Walk at Madras Museum Complex June 28, 2026 | 5.30-7 PM

Street Jam with OTS at Anna Nagar Tower Park Performance by Praptham June 28, 2026 | 6-7.30 PM

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